fiscal security. In gratitude for his outstanding work of the past ten years, Raja Todar Mal was made the imperial diwan in 1582.

Now a discontented group of noblemen revolted at attempts to curtail their power and the dilution of their coterie by the gradual introduction of Indian Muslims and Rajput noblemen into the mansabdari system. The Jesuits noted the pragmatic meritocracy of the Mughal court when they said that ‘men of low birth, upstarts, and (as the Mongols say) “men who have risen”, together with those of alien birth, are given posts in the royal household if the King finds them capable and efficient, and are gradually promoted’. But were these men ever to disappoint the Padshah they were made to ‘always carry about with them the tools of their original handicraft, lest in their vulgarity and insolence they ever forget the low station from which they have sprung’. It was clear, therefore, that while it was the Padshah’s prerogative to raise men when he discerned talent, it was not generally tolerated that people try and change their station of their own accord. ‘Whenever a domestic servant turns to ilm (scholarly business),’ Akbar said, ‘much business would remain unattended’. Superintendents were therefore warned to be vigilant so that no one wantonly abandoned their profession.

There was now an equal percentage of Rajput, Indian Muslim, and Persian noblemen, and just a fraction more Turani noblemen in the Mughal Empire. By 1580, the total number of Rajput mansabdars numbered 43, out of 272, while Persians accounted for 47 noblemen, Indian Muslims 44, with Turani noblemen having the highest number at 67. In addition to feeling that their clout was waning, the disgruntled noblemen had other reasons to be discontented. The recent innovation of the dagh, or branding, of horses that mansabdars were paid to maintain was particularly disliked. The outrage of the nobility was further stoked by the sadrs, who had been so unceremoniously ousted from their previously unassailable positions by the mazhar. Now all the disaffected noblemen of the east responded with violent enthusiasm to the fatwa issued by Mullah Yazdi. The ever-fractious Afghans of Bengal joined the Central Asian Qaqshals and the Bihar rebels. The Mughal Governor of Bengal was killed and Mirza Muhammad Hakim was recognized as the legitimate ruler of Hindustan. ‘They were not troubled by the thought,’ railed the historian Vincent Smith, ‘that the man whom they desired to substitute for their gifted monarch was a drunken sot,